

Listening vs Hearing

HEARING		LISTENING
I. Meaning	Hearing refers to one's ability to perceive sounds by receiving vibrations through the ears.	Listening is something done consciously that involves analysing and understanding the sounds you hear.
II. What is it?	It is an ability	It is a skill that can be learnt.
III. Nature	Primary and continuous	Secondary and temporary
IV. Act	Physiological	Psychological
V. Involves	Receipt of message through ears.	Interpretation of the message received by ears
VI. Process	Passive bodily process	Active mental process
VII. Occurs	It occurs at the Subconscious level	Occurs at the Conscious level
VIII. Use of senses	Only one; hearing requires the use of only one sense, i.e. ears	More than one: listening requires the use of more than one sense, i.e., eyes, ears and sometimes touch, to understand the message accurately
IX. Reason	We are neither aware of nor have any control over the sounds we hear	We listen to acquire knowledge and receive information
X. Concentration	Not required	Required

ACTIVE LISTENING

Active listening is the practice of preparing to listen, observing what verbal and non-verbal messages are being sent, and then providing appropriate feedback to show attentiveness to the message being presented. This form of listening conveys a mutual understanding between the speaker and listener.

There are three types of active listening. They are discussed below.

1) **Paraphrasing:** To paraphrase, one simply repeats what another individual has said. For example, the speaker might say, “She was foolish to quit her job.” The listener might respond, “I hear you saying that you believe she shouldn’t have quit.” Paraphrasing occurs when the listener clarifies what the speaker has said.

Example: Speaker: It just wasn’t the right thing for him to do.

Listener: You believe he shouldn’t have done that.

2) **Open Questions:** An open question explores a person’s statement without requiring a simple “yes” or “no” answer. The fundamental difference between an open question and a closed question is what they provide the person being asked. When asked an open question, it helps you think more about an issue. A closed question will not do that. It may force you to answer before you are ready or require a “yes” or “no” answer that doesn’t allow more thinking about the issue. Closed questions close the door on further thought, while open questions open the door. For example, the speaker might say, “I don’t like my job.” The listener might respond, “What is your job, and why don’t you like it?” or, “Tell me more about your feelings regarding your job.”

Example: Speaker: I didn’t like that show.

Listener: What didn’t you like about it?

3) **Feeling Reflection:** Feeling reflection is a response in which you express a feeling or emotion you have experienced about a particular statement. For example, the speaker might say, “I get sick of working so much overtime!” The listener might respond, “I hear you are angry and resentful at being asked to work so much overtime.” Feeling reflections are perhaps the most complex active listening responses to make. Not only do you actively listen to what is being said, but also you actively listen to what is being felt. When you make a feeling reflection, you are reflecting what you hear of another’s feelings. It is similar to paraphrasing; however, you repeat what you heard them feeling instead of what you heard them saying. To understand what individuals feel, you must listen to their words and tone of voice and watch their body signals. By observing all three, you can begin to guess their feelings.

Example: Speaker: I can’t stand to be kept waiting!

Listener: You’re pacing the floor, and your tone of voice tells me you feel this abuse of your time.

Difference between Active Listening and Passive Listening

Active Listening	Passive Listening
Active Listening is a process of transforming the thought or statement into a clear message,	Passive Listening is a process of simply consuming the message, but there is no involvement from the listener’s side.

with full involvement from the listener's side.	
Interactive	Mechanical
Reacting while listening	Listening without reacting
Two-way Communication	One-way Communication
Listener is present	The listener is not present.
The listener concentrates, understands, responds and remembers the statement spoken by the speaker.	The listener thinks about other topics while showing that they are listening.
The listener changes facial expression, rolls eyes, shows interest by questioning or smiling, etc.	The listener yawns, looks here and there, shows boredom, is silent, etc.

TYPES OF LISTENING

Based on the listening skills of the audience, listening can be classified into different types. They are discussed below:

Informative Listening: Informative listening or listening to understand is found in all our lives. Informative listening refers to a situation where the listener's primary concern is understanding the message.

Whenever you listen to learn something, you are engaged in informational listening. This occurs in many day-to-day situations, such as in education and at work, when you listen to the news, watch a documentary, hear a friend explain a recipe, or are guided through a technical issue with a computer. There are many other examples of informational listening as well.

Although all types of listening are "active" and require concentration and effort to understand, informational listening is less active than some other forms of listening. When we listen to learn or receive instructions, we absorb new information and facts without analysing or critiquing them. In formal settings like work meetings or educational environments, informational listening is often supported by note-taking, which helps to record key points for later review.

For example, a student listens to lectures or instructions from teachers - and what they learn depends on how well they listen. Three key variables related to informative listening are vocabulary, concentration and memory.

The precise relationship between vocabulary and listening has never been determined, but increasing your vocabulary will increase your potential for better understanding.

There are many reasons why people do not concentrate when listening. Sometimes, listeners try to divide their attention between two competing stimuli. At other times, listeners are preoccupied with something different than the speaker of the moment. Sometimes, listeners are too concerned with their own needs to concentrate on the message being delivered. Concentration requires discipline, motivation, and acceptance of responsibility.

More specifically, memory helps your informative listening to recall experiences and information necessary to function in the world around you.

Attentive Listening: Scholars have identified communication into three listening skill clusters and the accompanying behaviours that attentive listeners use. When people listen attentively, their goal is to understand and remember what they hear. The two skills in attentive listening are attention skills and following skills. Let us look at them.

Attention Skills involve inclining one's body towards the speaker, facing the speaker squarely, maintaining an open body position, using facial expressions to reflect emotions to the speaker, making eye contact and eliminating distracting noises, movements, etc. The following skills are keeping silent, giving another person time to decide whether to talk and attending to show interest.

Relationship Listening/Therapeutic or Empathic Listening: Relationship listening aims to help an individual or improve the relationship between people.

Therapeutic listening is a special type of relationship listening. Therapeutic listening brings to mind situations where counsellors, medical personnel, or other professionals allow a troubled person to discuss a problem. It can also be used when you listen to a friend or an acquaintance and let them get off the chest'. Although relationship listening requires you to listen for information, the emphasis is on understanding the other person. Three attitudes are key to an effective relationship: listening, attending, supporting, and empathising.

In relationship listening, attending behaviour indicates that the listener focuses on the speaker. Non-verbal cues are crucial in relationship listening; your non-verbal behaviour suggests whether you are attending to the speaker. Eye contact is one of the most essential attending behaviours. Many responses have a negative or non-supportive effect; for example, interrupting the speaker, changing the subject, turning the conversation towards oneself, and demonstrating a lack of concern for the other person. Wise relationship listeners know when to talk and when just to listen, and they generally listen more than they talk.

Empathy is feeling and thinking with another person. The empathic listener goes into the world of another to see as the other sees, hear as the other hears, and feel as the other feels.

Empathic listening involves trying to understand the feelings and emotions of the speaker by putting yourself in their shoes and sharing their perspective. Empathy helps create a deep

connection with another person, and empathic or therapeutic listening can be particularly challenging. Unlike sympathy, which is feeling compassion or pity for someone, empathy requires a deeper connection and understanding of the other person's point of view.

Professionals like counsellors and therapists often use empathic listening to understand better and help their clients. This type of listening does not involve making judgments or offering advice but instead encourages the speaker to express and explore their feelings. Techniques like clarification and reflection are commonly used to avoid misunderstandings.

We all can practice empathic listening with friends, family, and colleagues. Empathy is a valuable trait in relationships because it fosters trust and openness. You may feel more comfortable sharing your feelings with someone skilled at empathic listening, such as a close friend, spouse, parent, or sibling, often because of shared perspectives, experiences, and values.

Appreciative Listening: Appreciative listening includes listening for enjoyment. You will enjoy the speech because you like the style of the speaker. The quality of appreciative listening depends upon three factors such as presentation, perception, and previous experience. Let us learn them.

Presentation: Presentation encompasses many factors - the medium, the setting, the style, and the personality of the presenter, to name just a few. Sometimes, our perception of the presentation, rather than the actual presentation, influences our pleasure or displeasure in listening.

Perception: Expectations play a significant role in perception. Perceptions - and the expectations that drive them - have their basis in attitudes. Our attitudes determine how we react to and interact with the world. Perceptions influence all areas of our lives. Indeed, they are crucial determinants as to whether or not we enjoy or appreciate what we hear. Perceptions also determine what we listen to in the first place.

Previous Experience: Previous experience influences whether we enjoy listening to something. Sometimes, we enjoy listening to things because we are experts in the area. Previous experience plays a significant role in appreciative listening. For example, many people enjoy listening to music specific to their culture, as they have previous experience. People from other cultures may not appreciate the music.

Discriminative Listening: Discriminative listening is first developed at a very early age – perhaps even before birth, in the womb. It is the most basic form of listening and does not involve understanding the meaning of words or phrases but focuses on recognising different sounds. For example, in early childhood, a child can distinguish between the sounds of their parents' voices – the father's voice sounds different from the mother's.

Discriminative listening develops throughout childhood and into adulthood. As we grow older, gain experience, and develop, our ability to distinguish between sounds improves. We can recognise different voices and become better at noticing subtle differences in how sounds are made—an essential step toward understanding what those sounds mean. These differences

include recognising foreign languages, distinguishing between regional accents, and picking up on clues related to the emotions and feelings of the speaker.

By being sensitive to the speaker's rate, volume, force, pitch, and emphasis changes, the informative listener can detect even the slightest shift in nuances. Three things to consider about this type of listening are hearing ability, awareness of sound structure and integration of nonverbal cues. People who cannot hear well will have greater difficulty discriminating among sounds. Often, this problem is more acute for some frequencies or pitches than others. Native speakers become proficient at recognising vowel and consonant sounds, which means awareness of sounds that do or do not appear at the beginning, middle, or end of words. For example, a listener might hear 'this sandal' when the speaker said 'this handle'; since English words do not begin with 'sb', one would not mistake 'this be?' for 'this sbean'. Attention to the sound structure of the language will lead to more proficient discriminatory listening. Integration of Non-Verbal Cues, as stated earlier, action, non-action, and vocal factors are important for understanding messages. Nowhere is attention to these factors more important than in effective discriminative listening. Words do not always communicate true feelings. How they are said or the speaker's acts may be the key to understanding the true or intended meaning.

Being able to distinguish the subtle differences in sounds made by someone who is happy, sad, angry, or stressed adds valuable context to what is actually being said and helps with comprehension. We can better understand the speaker when discriminative listening skills are combined with visual cues, such as body language. For example, we might recognise that someone is sad, even if their words or tone suggest otherwise.

Example: Imagine yourself surrounded by people speaking a language you cannot understand, perhaps while passing through an airport in another country. You can likely distinguish between different voices—whether male or female, young or old—and gain some sense of what is happening around you based on the tone of their voices, their mannerisms, and body language. Even though you don't understand the words being spoken, you are using discriminative listening to grasp some understanding of your surroundings.

Comprehensive Listening: Comprehensive listening involves understanding the message or messages being communicated. Like discriminative listening, it is fundamental to all other types of listening. To effectively use comprehensive listening, the listener needs an appropriate vocabulary and language skills. Using overly complicated language or technical jargon can create barriers to comprehension.

Comprehensive listening can be challenging because two people listening to the same message may interpret it differently. This issue can become more complex in group settings, such as classrooms or business meetings, where multiple interpretations of what was said may arise.

Non-verbal communication, such as tone of voice, gestures, and body language, complements comprehensive listening. These signals can help improve understanding but can also lead to

confusion and misunderstanding. In many listening situations, seeking clarification and using techniques like reflection can aid comprehension.

Critical listening: Critical listening is the process of evaluating or scrutinising what is being said. It is a more active form of listening than informational listening and often involves problem-solving or decision-making. Like critical reading, it requires analysing the received information and comparing it with what we already know or believe. While informational listening focuses on absorbing facts or new information, critical listening assesses opinions and forms judgments.

In this context, “critical” doesn’t imply that the information is flawed. Instead, critical listening involves engaging with the content by asking questions such as, “What is the speaker trying to say?” or “What is the main argument?” and “How does this differ from my beliefs, knowledge, or opinion?” This type of listening is crucial for genuine learning.

Many everyday decisions are made through critical analysis, whether listening, reading, or thinking. Our opinions, values, and beliefs are shaped by our ability to process information, weigh pros and cons, and make informed decisions.

When listening critically, it’s important to keep an open mind and not be biased by stereotypes or preconceived ideas. By doing so, you can become a better listener, broaden your knowledge, and enhance your understanding of others and your relationships.

Rapport Listening: When trying to build rapport with others, we engage in listening that encourages the other person to trust and like us. For example, a salesperson may listen carefully to your words to foster trust and ultimately make a sale. This type of listening is often used in situations involving negotiation, where establishing a positive relationship is important.

Selective Listening: Selective listening is a more negative form of listening, where the listener is biased toward what they hear. This bias can be rooted in preconceived ideas or emotionally challenging conversations. Selective listening is a sign of poor communication because filtering out parts of the message prevents complete understanding. It can also reinforce or strengthen personal biases in future interactions, further hampering communication.

Intonation: (variation of pitch or loudness of the words in a sentence)

The intonation in a language refers to the patterns of pitch variation or the tones it uses in its utterances. In everyday speech, the pitch of our voice changes constantly – going up, going down, and sometimes remaining steady. Different pitches of the voice combine to form patterns of pitch variation or tones, which constitute intonation. Intonation is closely linked to stress because important changes in pitch occur with stressed syllables. The following are the main functions of intonation.

- 1) Distinguishing different utterances such as statements, commands, requests, and questions.

- 2) Differentiating the speaker's emotional attitude, such as curiosity, apprehension, friendliness, and politeness.
- 3) Drawing the listeners' attention to those segments of an utterance that one considers important.